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EPISODE 309

The Arayat

By Joseph Mosseri · Nov 11, 2026

Dedicated anonymously in loving memory of Bobby Isaac Dweck A"H, Yisrael Ben Hannah

This reading, in Arabic, instead of thinking of it in Hebrew as Keri'ah, in Arabic it will be Araya, and the plural of that would be Arayat.

Each day, these Hakhamim would come. Some would come early in the day, some would come later in the day, some would come so they can have breakfast, some would come so they could have lunch as well. Didn't make a difference. They were welcomed in, and they knew that they were doing their job, if you will, faithfully to read Lei'lui Nishmat HaNiftar.

And it would usually be the reading from the Zohar. Sometimes it would be Tehillim, but generally it would be from the Zohar, usually from the Idra, the Idra Rabba and the Idra Zuta. And these were commonly read throughout centuries in the house of the mourner, and the Hakhamim actually understood it, and they knew the words practically by heart. These were the books, for any of the old-timers around, you'd remember these books of the Hadrat Zekenim, and they would read from these books. And I have books of these Idra published in the 1800s, early 1900s, later 1900s all the way until 1948. And they were still being donated on 67th Street and in Shaare Zion. Later on, the Tehillim books from the 1930s and '40s that were being published in Yerushalayim and being donated and used as well.

Now, as we said, this reading was done by Hakhamim, Hakhamim that understood the words, that understood the meaning, and they read the Zohar diligently, understanding it, knowing it would raise the Neshamah of the Niftar.

At the end of the week of the Shib'ah, at the culmination of each day's Araya, then you would have the plural, all these Arayas would come together to be Arayat, the plural of Araya. And this Arayat would conclude on the day prior to the mourners rising up and leaving the mourning. It would start earlier in the day, reading, having a light lunch, continue reading. At the end of the day, at the end of the reading of the day, there would be Minhah, 'Arbit, speeches, Derush, Derushim, Derashot, followed by an actual meat dinner. And this was all done in the house. It wasn't done outside in the Knis, it wasn't done outside in a hall. This was all done in the Bet Ebel to elevate the Neshamah of the Niftar or the Nifteret. And that's the way it was done.

As time elapsed and these old-timers who knew the Zohar so well and weren't — they weren't

around anymore to read it, and others weren't — you know, they just couldn't get themselves to read words that they didn't understand and couldn't pronounce properly, Tehillim moved in, and Tehillim became the norm in many circles. There are still, you know, old-timers that insist on reading the Zohar, reading the Idra, and there is actually a comeback of people who are, you know, into that and are bringing back this old custom. But since the books aren't really available, and Tehillim is, you know, far and wide easily accessible, Tehillim still has the upper hand right now, and that's the actual reading at most of these things.

But the main point over here is not for people to come and to congregate and to hang out and talk, or for family members to get up and say, "Oh, how much, you know, I loved my grandfather," or how my, you know, "My grandmother was a great cook." It was all about the Dibre Torah, and that's why only Hakhamim would be involved in giving the speeches, which was a major factor in this Arayat at the end of the week.

The Hakhamim would get up and give Dibre Torah, Dibre Musar, and to help to encourage the family to emulate the positive attributes of the deceased, of doing more Torah UMissvot, of studying Torah UMissvot, and it was mainly for the people that were coming to comfort and to console the mourners, to help them as well to learn Torah and to bring more Torah into their lifestyles, and to use these Dibre Torah to elevate the soul.

So between the reading each day, which culminates at the seventh day Arayat, and the Dibre Torah given by the Hakhamim at the end of this week, this would all work together to elevate the soul of the deceased.

This would happen at the end of the week. It would always be done on the sixth day, unless — and listen very carefully — unless that sixth day was on Friday, so people are busy with Shabbat, so they would do it the day before, or if that sixth day fell out on Shabbat, we wouldn't do it on Shabbat or on Mossa'e Shabbat, so these things would get pushed back to Thursday. Otherwise, it was always done on a timely basis. It was not done for convenience's sake that we're going to make it on a day that we can get more people to attend. It wasn't about more people attending. It was — the factor here was helping the Neshamah, not helping other people.

And this was done the end of the Shib'ah, end of the week, the end of the one month period, and not the end of the year, but the end of 11 months, before the 12th month would begin. And this is when the Arayat and the Derushim would happen.

BeEzrat HaShem, we'll only know happy occasions, and if we need to refer to such information, we know where to find it. Tenuhamu Min HaShamayim.

(Disclaimer: This is a transcript of a video episode and may contain spelling or grammatical errors. As this transcript was generated from video, it may not fully capture the speaker's tone, emphasis, or intent — we recommend watching the video for the full experience and accuracy.)